

Mind Your Language!

British Broadcasting Corporation—if you don’t know them, you have no excuse. As far as credibility, quality and authority is concerned, we can take their *word* for it, irrespective of the language.

BBC offers its services in a wide range of languages—from Chinese, French, German, to Greek and Spanish. Now considering you want to learn French... or *Francaise*, then all you need to do is click on Choose a Language > French (FRA).



A cool and friendly look makes it easy to use

Once you’re at the page for the language of your choice, it’s smooth sailing. Click on Learn Online > Online courses. From here, it’s all self-explanatory and meant to be that way, so that you don’t have to be dependent on anyone.

Click on start, and you’ll step in to a whole new world. You’ll see many probable situations that you could probably encounter in real life. As an example, click on Short break in Paris > Getting a snack. It shows you the most common dialogues that could crop up in a restaurant. For example, the waiter comes up to you and asks—what would you like? Considering you already know the tongue-twisting names of dishes available on the menu, you should be able to reply in crisp French, “I’ll have a cheese sandwich”. In addition, it also has the pronunciation for the keywords used in the conversation. This comes in very handy, especially, with a language like French—it’s written one way and pronounced some other! If you have no prior knowledge of the language, then use the audio clips, so that you get the authentic pronunciation.

Livemocha

This site adds the benefit of collective intellect in the form of social networking, to spice up your learning experience. After registering on the site and confirming your e-mail address for authenticity, enter the languages you know and the languages you want to learn.

Live Mocha shows you a list of users with



A vibrant site in the way it brings together people from across the globe

the opposite needs. Say for example, you know English and Hindi, and want to learn German, then Live Mocha will show you all the native German speakers who want to learn English or Hindi.

You get the best of both worlds. Not only do you get authentic advice on the language of your choice, but also get to make new friends, who give you the consolation of talking to another human, rather than interacting with a server.



Monitor your learning curve from a dedicated inbox

Live Mocha brings you an easy-to-follow inbox, through which you can monitor exactly where you stand in your learning curve. You get to see users who’re learning the same language as you and users who speak the same language as you. This way, learning is easy and comfortable.

BYKI

The last site that we present here, has a dedicated software for each language. The number of them in total—a massive 64! As far as the methodology goes, it’s quite similar to the good old way that BBC follows. What sets this apart though, is the host of languages. You get dedicated software for each language. Go to www.byki.com/default.html.



With a vast list of 64 languages available for offline learning, BYKI has an added benefit.

First select the language you want to learn. Say for example, you want to learn Spanish, just click on the link that says Spanish under Free Language Software Downloads. Enter your e-mail address to receive the download link. Once you click on the link sent to you to for verification, download the installer that follows. Once you run the setup, BYKI automatically downloads the required files needed for a smooth study. The installer by itself is just 105 KB. However, the files that it downloads can go on for quite a while, especially if you have a slow Internet connection. You’ll be reminded of your typical Yahoo! messenger downloads.

Once the files are completely downloaded, you have software residing on your system—you no longer need Internet access, neither are you pressurised to learn in any time frame. You can use the software for as long as you wish—it’s fully functional, completely free, with no time limits.

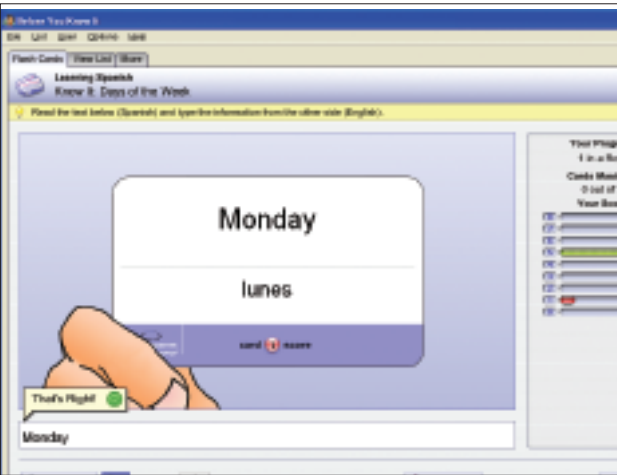
With BYKI, learning a language gets really exciting. The striking difference is that you’re not distracted, as you don’t really need an Internet connection once you have downloaded the files and set up the software. It plays you the audio recorded by a native speaker. BYKI proceeds in steps—the test gets stringent with each passing stage. You need to review your cards, recognise, know, produce and finally own your cards.

Say for example, we’re learning the days of the week. Then in this case, you’ll be flashed seven cards with the names of the day written in Spanish as well as English. Once you’re familiar with the cards that you have, it proceeds with the test.

While recognising, you’re given the option to think and are given the choice of verifying whether you guessed it right. This way, although you’re being tested, it’s not obvious!

In the Know It stage, you’re shown the word in Spanish. You need to type the English word for it. Similarly, in Produce It, you’re shown the English term, and you need to reproduce the Spanish term. This way with all permutations and combinations, your ability on a particular subject is thoroughly scanned.

We believe it would be grave injustice to compare these resources among themselves, because as we said earlier—*needs differ and so do solutions*. So while one site may appear a boon to one person, it just may not work out for another. To get the most out of these resources and to learn faster, select the resource of your choice depending on the way you respond faster. If you’re more comfortable with a friend teaching you, then Live Mocha is certainly the place for you. Similarly, if you’re one of those who get distracted easily while browsing and need some time of concentration to be able to learn, BYKI is definitely your solution.



With BYKI, you monitor yourself

Another reason for BYKI is if your language isn’t covered in the other two sites, which can most probably be the case if it is some rare and exotic language! At the end, if the language that you intend to learn is one of the popular ones, then it is, in all probability, covered by BBC Languages. Additionally, it has a vast range of resources—grammar, dictionary, TV and radio programmes, etc. The opportunities are literally endless, and you would certainly feel the culture of the country lighting up as you go about studying its language.

There’s more to Spanish than *uno*, *dos* and *tres*! ☒

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